



Podcasting

What is podcasting?

Podcasting is a way of delivering audio over the Internet. It's something like Internet radio, with the difference being that you can subscribe to a podcast, have it downloaded, and listen to it at any time you wish.

Where can I listen to a podcast?

Although the word 'podcasting' is derived from 'iPod' and 'broadcasting', you don't need an iPod to listen to a podcast. All you need is the requisite software, and you can listen to a podcast on any computer that has the software.

Why is podcasting an interesting development?

Podcasting is sort of like Internet radio with the added benefit that you can listen to the show any time you want. It allows individuals to distribute shows over the Internet. While it's not possible for any individual to walk into a radio station and demand a certain broadcast, any individual with the right equipment can do a podcast.

How does podcasting work?

You can subscribe to a podcast using a software called a podcatcher. The system uses the format called RSS 2.0 (or RDF XML) with enclosures (the podcast is the enclosed data). This is somewhat similar to the RSS feeds on the Internet many of us subscribe to.

When did podcasting first become popular?

It's possible that the first use of the term 'podcasting' was in an article by Ben Hammersley in The Guardian on February 12, 2004. By October 2004, detailed how-to-podcast articles had begun to appear online.

Who can podcast?

Anyone! With the right software and minimal hardware requirements, that is. Just Google "How do I create a podcast" and find the answers!

of films, even though content is wrapped in copy-protection technology to prevent unauthorised sharing.

Downloads are available on a 'pay-as-you-go' basis with prices of between £1.50 (Rs 118) for a music video, and £6.99 (Rs 550) and upwards for a full DVD. That's more expensive than renting a DVD, but the BiBC hopes the convenience of not having to go to a shop will appeal to potential customers.

By the looks of it, BoxOffice365.com wants to do for video downloads what iTunes did for legal music downloads. It's one of a small group of companies trying to change the way people enjoy films and video downloads.

SHOWTIME!

Hackers Demonstrate Their Skills In Vegas

Even the ATM machines were suspect at this year's Defcon conference, where hackers played intrusion games at the bleeding edge of computer security. With some of the world's best digital break-in artists pecking away at their laptops, sending e-mails or answering cell phones could also be risky.

Defcon is a no-man's land where customary adversaries—Government Security and technology experts—spar with digital mavericks. The result is sharing ideas about making the Internet a safer place. In reality, however, it's just hackers flexing their wits and muscles.

This year's hot topics included a demonstration of just how easy it may be to attack supposedly foolproof biometric safeguards, which determine a person's identity by scanning such things as thumbprints,

irises and voice patterns. Banks, supermarkets and even some airports have begun to rely on such systems, but a security analyst who goes by the name Zamboni challenged hackers to bypass biometrics by attacking their backend systems networks.

Also on hand at the conference was Robert Morris, former chief scientist for the National Security Agency, to lecture on the vulnerabilities of banking ATMs, which he predicted would become the next "pot of gold" for hackers.



Hackers and the computer security experts who make a living on tripping up systems say security would be better if people were less lazy. To make their point, they pilfered Internet passwords from convention attendees. Anyone naive enough to access the Internet through the hotel's unsecured wireless system could see their name and part of their passwords scrolling across a huge public screen. It was dubbed the 'The Wall of Sheep'.

Amongst the exposed sheep were an engineer from Cisco Systems, multiple employees from

Apple Computer, and a Harvard professor. Baa!

CORPORATE PODCASTS?

Big Blue To Podcast

IBM is all set to embrace Podcasting, the digital audio craze that allows consumers to take audio programming off the Web and listen to it on portable music players. The

company plans to introduce a series of occasional Podcasts on its investor relations site as part of a broader effort to communicate directly to its investors and the wider public about hot topics.

The Podcasts would be insights on emerging issues. The company has emphasised that the Podcasts would not be IBM commercials. The company also sees these Podcasts replacing the traditional whitepapers. ■

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